

FOREWORD

by His Holiness the Dalai Lama

Tara, a solace predicted by the Unequalled Lion of the Shakyas, is the enlightened compassionate activity of all the Sugatas of the three times, perfect and complete with all of the auspicious marks to be revealed to the senses of the fortunate ones wishing for liberation. As we see in the accounts of the past masters, many incredible beings in Tibet and in the holy land of India such as Atisha Dipamkara and the supreme Victor Gendun Drup (the first Dalai Lama) have, by practicing Tara, performed magnificent enlightened activities for the benefit of beings. Similarly now, Khenpo Tsulnam of Jang Chup Teg Sum Ling in Taiwan has composed this book, now translated in English and Chinese, in a few sections from the history of Tara and other texts. I express my praise and rejoice in this composition and pray that from its study, contemplation, and meditation, effortless and spontaneous enlightened activities come forth.

Bikshu of the Shakyas,

Expounder of the Dharma,

the Dalai Lama.

April, 18, 2009

Preface and Translator's Acknowledgments

The Twenty-One Praises to Tara is a prayer that most Tibetans and other Himalayan Buddhists have memorized since childhood. However, the meaning of its terse verses is incomprehensible without commentary. Their profound meaning lends itself to interpretation on many different levels according to the different systems of tantra. The root verses thus present specific difficulties for translation, as they need to be rendered in a way that works with a variety of commentaries. Each syllable of the verses often has a meaning quite unrelated to the next syllable, making a translation that is both elegant and faithful nearly impossible. Past translations have often inserted new, interpretive text to make the root verses more intelligible to a surface reading. But this practice eliminates the possibility of reading them in tandem with other commentaries. I've endeavored to retain something of the style of the Tibetan, which is not immediately comprehensible without commentary, but also tried my best, with the kind help of my editor, to style the verses in metre for ease of chanting. To Tibetans, Tara is the main deity to whom they pray for the removal of obstacles and fears. When family members are ill or before beginning new business ventures, setting out to travel, or starting any important activities they will recite *the Twenty-one Praises*, or make donations to the monasteries to do so. While Tibetans have faith in Tara by virtue of enculturation and chant these verses of praise with devotion, most Western devotees do not and must actively cultivate that feeling of devotion over time by practicing and studying commentaries such as *The Glorious Bestower of All Desires*, an explanation of the outer meaning of *the Twenty-one Praises* presented here by Khenpo Tsulnam.

The second main text in this volume is the commentary to *The Tara Ritual of the Four Mandalas*. Khenpo Tsulnam asked me to not add many footnotes as this is a profound practice text which should be read by knowledgeable practitioners with the correct transmissions, therefore many technical terms are left as-is with no explanation. This practice comes from the *Profound Essence of Tara* or *Zap Tik* cycle of mind-treasure teachings revealed by the great nineteenth century treasure revealer Chokgyur Dechen Lingpa¹.

I am grateful for the many hours of personal teachings on the text from Khenpo Tsulnam through whom I learned much about Tara, Vajrayana theory, ritual, and more. Thanks to Dzongsar Khyentse Rinpoche who, very auspiciously-just after Khenpo Tsulnam asked me to translate these texts, gave teachings on Tara and also imparted the reading transmission of the *Profound Essence*. I also wish to acknowledge the assistance of Khenpo Tsulnam's brother Khenpo Kunga, Khenpo Yugyal, and other teachers here at Sherab Ling Monastery. Any elegance in the English, especially in the root verses, is due to the editing work of James Bradwell, for which I am very appreciative. Thanks to Damian and Tenzang for their caring advice and for making me feel at home here in Sherab Ling, and finally thanks to Tai Situ Rinpoche, without whose blessings this project and our coming together would not have been possible.

Any flaws in this translation are mine alone. Though thoroughly unqualified for this task, I have completed to fulfill the wish of Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche. By the merit that comes from this translation, may all sentient beings attain buddhahood inseparable from Arya Tara.

Justin Kirkwood (Sherab Gyaltsen)
Sherab Ling Monastery
Upper Bhattu, India
January, 2012

¹ For more information on Chokgyur Lingpa's life and the lineage of the Chokling Tersar see Tulku Urgyen Rinpoche's *Blazing Splendor* and Orgyen Tobgyal Rinpoche's *The Life of Chokgyur Lingpa*.

Introduction

by Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche

I have composed this book in three sections. First is Tara's story. I wrote this mainly to generate interest and faith in practitioners. In order to do Tara practice, one must have faith and devotion in Tara. By learning about Tara's great compassion, enlightened activities, and blessing power, one will gain devotion and interest in her blessings and practice.

Second is the commentary to the *Twenty-one Praises to Tara*. Generally, there are two types of commentaries to this text. One which focuses primarily on Tara herself, and the second which describes the twenty-one Taras individually. This commentary is the latter, focusing on twenty-one Taras' enlightened activities and ways of benefiting beings. There are also many different commentaries, both common and uncommon- the uncommon having application to the generation and completion stages of vajrayana practice. Here I have made a general commentary that may be read by anyone, without mention of the hidden or secret meanings of the verses.

Third is the commentary to the *Tara Ritual of the Four Mandalas*. I wrote this because, although there are many commentaries of the *Twenty-one Praises to Tara* in Tibetan, and now even in English, I have never seen a commentary to the *Tara Ritual of the Four Mandalas*. Here I briefly explain the practice of Tara, the gathering of the accumulations, and the creation and completion stages. It is a commentary sharing elements of both Sutra and Tantra.

A note on mantra pronunciation: This text contains many mantras which are all in English phonetics taken from the Tibetan pronunciations. Generally, as much as we can refine the pronunciations (to the real Sanskrit pronunciations) that is probably good but on the other hand, faith, belief, and lineage are extremely important. For example, we Tibetans say BENZA in the Vajrasattva and Vajra Guru mantras. There is no ZA sound in Sanskrit, but rather JA. Nevertheless, the power of the mantra comes forth, empowered by our belief and the blessings of the lineage.

Once upon a time, long ago in the land of multicolored light, there lived a Buddha called Drum Sound. In that land, there was a princess called Wisdom Moon who had faith in and respect for his teachings. After many hundreds of thousands of years serving and making offerings to Drum Sound and his retinue of bodhisattvas, she finally generated bodhicitta in his presence. At that time the bhikshus¹ said that, since a female body is inferior to a male body, she should pray, with the merit she had accumulated, to be reborn as a man in order to serve the Dharma. That would be the appropriate thing to do, they assured her, since such an aspiration would be fulfilled.

She replied:

Here there is neither man nor woman—
No self, no person, no consciousness.
The labels “male” and “female” have no essence;
The foolish worldly ones are thoroughly mistaken.

As there are many men who wish for enlightenment, but few women who accomplish the benefit of beings, Wisdom Moon pledged, "Until the emptying of samsara, I will work for the benefit of beings in a woman's body." Then, staying in the king's palace, she remained in samadhi while making use of all objects of enjoyment, as she had become skilled in means² towards them. She thereby attained forbearance towards the non-arising of phenomena—the realization that all phenomena are unborn. She then attained the samadhi called "liberating all beings." By the power of that samadhi, she accomplished the benefit of many sentient beings every morning, liberating them from our world-system. She would not eat until she had established them in forbearance.³ Similarly, every evening, she liberated many sentient beings from samsara; thus her name became “Liberator.” The Buddha Drum Sound predicted that, until she attained buddhahood and thereafter, she should be called Tara and appear in a woman's body. So, while on the paths of training and after attaining buddhahood, at all times has she been known as Tara and manifested in a woman's body. Because she made an oath before the Buddha Amoghasiddhi to protect sentient beings from all harmful obstacles, she is praised above all other deities for the clearing of obstacles. She appeared in this world-system by taking birth from the tears of Arya Avalokiteshvara. The Bhagavan said, “Manjushri, this great lady is the mother of all Buddhas of the three times. Therefore, Manjushri, you should keep in mind this, the praise of all Buddhas of the three times.” Then the Bhagavan spoke the dharani of the praise together with the mantra:

OM JE TSUN PAG MA DROL MA LA CHAG TSEL LO

OM, Homage to the Reverend Arya Tara

OM means protector, going for refuge, offering, and making circumstances auspicious. It also symbolizes the body, speech, and mind of all Buddhas. *JE* means supreme; Tara is the supreme mother of all the Victors of the three times. *TSUN* means separate from all faults and wrongdoing. *PAG MA* means superior, as Tara is superior to ordinary beings and those on the paths of training. *DROL MA* means to liberate. Tara liberates from samsara and from all fears. *CHAG* means to sweep away all karma, mental afflictions, and obscurations. *TSEL* means to bow down respectfully with body, speech, and mind.

1 Fully ordained monk.

2 Here "skilled in means" means that because all her actions are sealed by bodhicitta, rather than abandoning all objects in renunciation, she may make use of them freely, without attachment.

3 The forbearance that one attains upon the first moment of the path of seeing.

༄༅། །སྒྲོལ་མ་ཉིར་གཅིག་གི་བསྟོད་འགྲེལ་འདོད་ཀྱི་ཏེ་
འཕྲིན་ལས་དཔལ་སྟེར་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་
བཞུགས་སོ།།

The Glorious Bestower of All Desires
A Commentary on the Twenty-One Praises to Tara

by Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche

Om svasti. Having bowed down to the twenty-one goddesses
Who display whatever lovely, youthful forms are required
By the different dispositions of all those to be trained,
I will joyfully compose the *Glorious Bestower*.

The *Homage in Twenty-One Praises to Tara*, spoken by the Buddha Vairochana, shall briefly be explained in respect to the praise of each of the twenty-one Taras.

CHAK TSEL DRÖL MA NYÜR MA PA MO
CHEN NI KAY CHIK LOK TANG DRA MA
JIK TEN SÜM GÖN CHÜ KYEY SHEL GYI
GEY SAR JAY WA LAY NI JÜNG MA

*Homage! Tara, swift and heroic,
Whose eyes are quick like lightning,
Who arose from the open lotus blossom
From the face of the protector of the three worlds.*

The first verse is an homage and praise to Tara Nyurma Pamo, “Swift Heroine.” She is orange in color. Her right hand forms the mudra of offering and generosity. In her left hand is an utpala flower, upon which rests a white, clockwise-twisting conch shell which represents her glory and fame, that pervade the three worlds. With tremendous love and compassion, she frees all sentient beings without exception from samsara. Swiftly and without obstruction, she engages in the enlightened activities that fulfill the welfare of beings. She is heroic, having the power to conquer all evil spirits and obstacles. Her eyes of primordial wisdom realize the nature of all objects of knowledge instantly, with a mere moment's glance, like a flash of lightning. Thus she possesses the enlightened activities of wisdom, love and power. She arose from the open lotus that sprang from the tears of Avalokiteshvara, the protector of the three worlds.

CHAK TSEL TÖN KAY DA WA KÜN TŪ
GANG WA GYA NI TSEK PAY SHEL MA
KAR MA TONG TRAK TSOK PA NAM KYI
RAB TŪ CHEY WAY Ö RAB BAR MA

*Homage! Her face is like an array
Of one hundred full autumn moons
Who blazes with the brilliant, expansive light
Of the gathering of one thousand stars.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Loter Yangchenma, “Sarasvati, Treasury of Intelligence.” The goddess's color is like an autumn moon. Her exquisite white face is like a hundred moons at their fullest. Her right hand forms the mudra of offering and generosity; in her left, she holds an utpala flower. Upon the flower stands a mirror, like a full moon, marked with the syllable *HRIH*. Like the light from the

gathering of one thousand stars, the bright, illuminating rays of her intelligence dispel the darkness of obscuring ignorance from the minds of practitioners, arouse their intelligence, bring the blazing illumination of wisdom, and open the gateway to all objects of knowledge.

CHAK TSEL SER NGO CHÜ NAY KYEY KYI
PAY MAY CHAK NI NAM PAR GYEN MA
JIN PA TSÖN DRÜ KA TÜB SHI WA
ZÖ PA SAM TEN CHÖ YÜL NYI MA

*Homage! Golden mother whose hand is adorned
With a blue water-born lotus,
Whose fields of activity are generosity,
Diligence, austerity, peace, patience, and meditation.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Sermo Tobkyema, “The Golden One Who Generates Power.” She is of a golden, yellow color. A blue utpala lotus flower adorns her left hand. Ornamenting that flower is a wish-fulfilling jewel, which rains down whatever beings desire. Within the scope of her activity fall all the thirty-seven factors conducive to enlightenment, such as the six perfections of generosity, diligence, the discipline of austerity, the wisdom that is peace, patience, and meditation.

CHAK TSEL DE SHIN SHEK PAI TSÜK TOR
TA YAY NAM PAR GYEL WA CHÖ MA
MA LÜ PA ROL CHIN PA TOB PAY
GYEL WAY SAY KYI SHIN TÛ TEN MA

*Homage! Mother, the crown¹ of the Tathagatas,
Who experiences limitless victory—
The heirs of the Conqueror rely upon her fully;
They attain all the perfections.*

Here the object of homage is Chimey Tsedrubpa Tsugtor Nampargyalma, “Üshnisha-Emanated Conqueror, Achiever of Immortality.” Golden in color, she holds the vase of immortality. She emanated from the crown of the Tathagata as the goddess of awareness mantra. The scope of her activity encompasses complete victory over death and other endless, unfavorable conditions. She is the mother of the bodhisattvas who have attained the ten perfections—the essence of the ten bhumis. Thus they rely on her fully and respectfully. She makes the pure essences of the life and merit of all existence dissolve into practitioners and increase within them.

CHAK TSEL TÛT TA RA HÜNG YI GE
DÖ TANG CHOK TANG NAM KHA GANG MA
JIK TEN DÜN PO SHAP KYI NEN TE
LÜ PA MAY PAR GÜK PAR NÜ MA

1 Sanskrit *ushnisha*, the protuberance at the crown of the Buddha’s head, one of the 32 major marks of a buddha.

*Homage! With the mantras TÜTTARA and HÜNG,
She fills the desire, the directions, and space;
She stamps down the seven worlds,
To all she has the power of magnetism.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Wangdue Rigje Lhamo, “Magnetizing Goddess of Knowledge.” Her color is red, and she radiates rays of light that attract beings. The sound of *HÜNG*, which represents that her mind is the union of emptiness and great compassion, fills the desire realm, the directions (the form realm), and space (the formless realm). Thus, as if trampling them under foot, she brings under her power the seven worlds of the nagas, pretas, asuras, humans, awareness-holders, kinnaras, and gods. In brief, to all sentient beings without exception—both with and without form—she bestows the siddhi¹ of magnetizing everything they desire.

**CHAK TSEL GYA CHIN MAY LHA TSANG PA
LÜNG LHA NA TSOK WANG CHÜK CHÖ MA
JÜNG PO RO LANG DRI SA NAM TANG
NÖ CHIN TSOK KYI DÜN NAY TÖ MA**

*Homage! Various gods—Indra, Agni, Brahma
Vayudeva, and Ishvara—present offerings
To her before whom throngs of ghosts,
Vetalas², gandharvas, and yakshas sing praises.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Jigje Chenmo, “Great Terrifying One,” who destroys every kind of harmful spirit. Her color is dark red, and she holds a ritual dagger. Sparks of *HÜNG* shoot forth from her body. Indra, the chief of the gods; the rishis; Agni; Brahma, who claims to be the creator of the world; Vayudeva; the guardians of the directions and so forth; and other mighty ones of the world, such as Shiva, all tremble with fear at the sight of her and respectfully make offerings to her. With her glory, she subdues the hosts of Indra—harmful spirits, obstructing spirits, and misleading spirits—and the host of the rakshas—vetalas, gandharvas, beings of the intermediate state, the world of spirits of the lord of death, yakshas, spirits that cause madness, mischievous spirits, and flesh-eaters. She subdues and destroys the multitude of harms and hindrances they inflict. Thus they fear her. Their arrogance toppled by faith, they praise her respectfully with body, speech, and mind.

**CHAK TSEL TRE CHE CHA TANG PEY KYI
PA ROL TRÜL KOR RAB TÜ JOM MA
YAY KÜM YÖN KYANG SHAP KYI NEN TE
MAY BAR TRÜK PA SHIN TÜ BAR MA**

*Homage! With TRE and PET,
She utterly destroys the machinations of foes.*

1 An attainment gained through assiduous spiritual practice.

2 A spirit that inhabits the charnel grounds and possesses corpses.

*Right leg folded, left extended, pressing,
She burns, trembling, blazing.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Tummo Zhengyi Mithubma, “Fierce, Invincible One,” who dispels wars, hail storms, and lightning. As she utters the mantras *PET*—which means to split open—and *TRET*—which means separate—the sound completely destroys the machinations of others: black magic, ill will, hail storms, lightning, and war. Her right leg is bent, her left extended, symbolizing emptiness and compassion, whereby she avoids dwelling in the extremes of either samsara or nirvana. Her extended left leg presses down the fierce afflictions¹, evil spirits, and maras, and saves sentient beings from the fears of samsara and nirvana. Black in color, she burns with the fire of primordial wisdom. Her face is slightly wrathful and trembling. In her left hand, she holds an utpala flower upon which stands a sword, blazing with light that burns up the multitude of harms inflicted by enemies.

CHAK TSEL TŪ RAY JIK PA CHEN MO
DÜ KYI PA WO NAM PAR JOM MA
CHÜ KYE SHEL NI TRO NYER DEN DZE
DRA WO TAM CHE MA LÜ SÖ MA

*Homage! The terrifying one, TÜRE,
Completely vanquishes the bold maras;
Her lotus face frowning wrathfully,
She kills all enemies² without exception.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Zhen Migyalwai Pamo, “Unconquered Heroine,” who destroys criticism, opposition, and so on. Dark red in color, she has a wrathful, grimacing face. She holds a vajra in her left hand. *TÜRE* means swiftness. By manifesting this terrifying form from the expanse of peace, and by reciting the mantra *OM TARE*, etc., she destroys the hardest of maras to tame: the afflictions and birth, aging, sickness and death. Her face, peaceful and beautiful as a lotus, takes on a wrathful aspect to tame maras, the negative opposition of others, and obstacles. By eliminating harmful intentions and actions, she kills all the enemies who harm the Buddhadharma, the holders of the teachings, and sentient beings.

CHAL TSEL KÖN CHOK SÜM TSÖN CHAK GYAY
SOR MO TŪK KAR NAM PAR GYEN MA
MA LÜ CHOK KYI KOR LO GYEN PAI
RANG GI Ö GI TSOK NAM TRÜK MA

*Homage! Adorning her heart, her fingers
Form the mudra³ signifying the Three Jewels;
The all-directional wheel adorns.*

1 The *kleshas*, or mental afflictions of desire, anger, pride, ignorance, doubt, and wrong view.
2 Here killing symbolizes the victory over the afflictions, or *kleshas*.
3 A ritual hand gesture.

Her light battles with the host⁴.

Here the object of homage is Sengdeng Nagkyi Dolma, “Tara of the Teak Forest,” who brings salvation from all danger. Her body is emerald-green. Her right hand forms the mudra of supreme generosity. In her left, between her thumb and ring finger, she holds the stem of an utpala flower adorned by a wheel with shimmering spokes that point in the ten directions. The remaining fingers of her left hand, which rests at her heart, point upwards in representation of the Three Jewels. Light radiates from her, illuminating all sentient beings in the four directions and does battle with, or pacifies, the host of fears, which are eight or sixteen² in number.

CHAK TSEL RAP TŪ GA WA JI PAI
Ü GYEN Ö KYI TRENG WA PEL MA
SHE PA RAP SHAY TŪT TA RA YI
DŪ TANG JIK TEN WANG DŪ DZAY MA

*Homage! Her majestic crown of joy
Radiates a rosary of alternating lights;
With her great laughing TŪTTARA,
She subjugates maras and worldly beings.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Jigten Sumgyal, “Conqueror of the Three Worlds,” who brings all worlds under her power. She is red in color and holds a victory banner in her hand. She effortlessly grants all the wishes of disciples. From her crown, which creates supreme joy for sentient beings, alternating, multicolored rays of light shine forth. By that light and by the laughing sound from her mouth of the mantra TŪTTARA—endowed with eight kinds of laughter—Mara Kamadeva, the lord of the desire realm; Brahma and Indra, the chiefs of the world; gods and nagas; kings; queens; ministers; sons; daughters' householders; the ordained; and so on are all brought under her power. She grants this siddhi of subjugation to all who pray to her with faith.

CHAK TSEL SA SHI KYONG WAY TSOK NAM
TAM CHEY GÜK PAR NŪ PA NYI MA
TRO NYER YO WAY YI GEY HÜNG GI
PONG PA TAM CHE NAM PAR DRÖL MA

Homage! She is able to summon

4 Some other editions print *rang gi 'od kyī tshogs*, which would make this read as “the host or mass of light radiates out” instead of here, where the Tibetan reads *rang gi 'od kyis tshogs*, making the light the agent doing “battle” with the host.

2 The eight fears are fear of elephants, lions, fire, snakes, thieves, imprisonment, water, and demons. The sixteen fears are fear of a king's punishment, gods, sickness caused by earth spirits, epidemic, famine, war, harm by rishis, ghosts and spirits, lightning, frost and hail, earthquakes, fire, water, meteors, garudas, and ill-omened dreams. The symbolic meanings of the eight fears are as follows: elephants=blindness, lions=pride, fire=anger, snakes=jealousy, thieves=erroneous philosophies, imprisonment=greed, water=desire and attachment, and demons=doubts. See Bokar Rinpoche's *Tara the Feminine Divine* (San Francisco: ClearPoint Press, 1999), p.25.

*All the hosts of local guardians.
With a wrathful, shivering frown, by the syllable HÜNG
She completely liberates all the poor.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Üsel Norter Tronyerchen, “Dispelling Poverty and Bestowing Wealth.” She has the power to summon all the guardians of the earth, the earth goddesses, nagas, yakshas, and the host of wealth gods as her servants to carry out whatever she commands. She is orange in color and appears in a slightly wrathful aspect. In her hand she holds a treasure vase. The rays of light from the syllable *HÜNG* at her heart summon all the wealth and resources of the gods, nagas and humans. All the wealth desired by sentient beings falls like rain, thus completely liberating them from the sufferings of poverty.

**CHAK TSEL DA WA DÜM BÜ Ü GYEN
GYEN PA TAM CHEY SHIN TÛ BAR MA
RAL PAY TRO NAY Ö PA MAY LAY
TAK PAR SHIN TÛ Ö RAP DZAY MA**

*Homage! Her half moon crown and
All her adornments brightly blaze.
Light shines ever brilliantly
From Amitabha on the topknot of her hair.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Tashi Dondrupma, “Accomplisher of Good Fortune,” who brings good fortune to all lands. The goddess is golden in color. Her left hand holds an utpala flower on which rests an auspicious endless knot. Rays of light shine from the half moon that adorns her head, sending forth a rain of nectar that enriches trees, grains, and flowers. All her silken garments and precious jewelry cast forth brilliant, magnificent rays of light, which bring good fortune to all worlds. In the silky, gleaming black hair arranged upon her head dwells Buddha Amitabha, lord of her buddha family. Rays of light, which are compassion suffused with the illumination of of sublime virtue and goodness, blaze brilliantly and utterly—that is, at all times—from Amitabha. Thereby, for the benefit of beings and for the good fortune of the outer environment and its inhabitants, she temporarily and, at last, ultimately sets them in the splendor of good fortune, peace, and well-being.

**CHAK TSEL KEL PAY TA MAY MAY TAR
BAR WAI TRENG WAY Ü NA NAY MA
YAY KYANG YÖN KÜM KÜN NAY KOR GEY
DRA YI PÜNG NI NAM PAR JOM MA**

*Homage! She abides amidst a garland
That blazes like the fire at the end of an aeon;
Right leg extended, left drawn in,
Encircled and joyful, she destroys the enemy host.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Drapung Jomma, “Destroyer of the Enemy Host,” who wins

victory in war and surmounts all obstacles. Red in color, she dwells in the middle of a dense garland of primordial wisdom fire, which blazes like the fire at the end of an aeon. She bears a wrathful expression. Her right leg is stretched out, her left bent in. In her left hand, she holds up a vajra; from it emanate other tiny, blazing vajras that, through great compassion, conquer harmful enemies. This rain of vajras returns to the vajra in her hand, then becomes a vajra tent, completely surrounding her. Thus she brings joy to the faithful and destroys all enemies, inner and outer.

CHAK TSEL SA SHI NGO LA CHAK GI
TIL GYI NÜN CHING SHAP GYI DÜNG MA
TRO NYER CHEN DZAY YI GEY HÜNG GI
RIM PA DÜN PO NAM NI GEM MA

*Homage! She strikes the surface of the earth
With the palm of her hand, stamps it with her feet.
Frowning wrathfully, she destroys those
On the seven levels with the syllable HÜNG*

Here the object of homage is Tara Tronyerchen Dzema, “Scowling One,” who destroys obstacles and evil spirits. She is black in color. In her left hand she holds an utpala flower; on top of it stands a wooden pestle. She pounds the ground with her right hand, which is in the threatening mudra, and stamps it with the soles of her feet, shaking the earth. She has an angry and wrathful aspect. From the syllable *HÜNG* at her heart fly vajra weapons that destroy the bodies and lives of harmful spirits and obstacle-makers all the way down to the seventh subterranean level¹, liberating them into the dharmadhatu and cutting the flow of their negative karma.

CHAK TSEL DAY MA GEY MA SHI MA
NYA NGEN DAY SHI CHÖ YÜL NYI MA
SO HA OM TANG YANG DAK DEN PAY
DIK PA CHEN PO JOM PA NYI MA

*Homage! Blissful, virtuous, and tranquil,
She partakes of the peace beyond suffering,
And, perfectly endowed with SVAHA and OM,
She destroys great misdeeds.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Rابتu Zhima, “Perfectly Calm,” who pacifies misdeeds and obscurations. White in color, she holds an utpala flower in her left hand. Upon the flower stands an anointing vase filled with purifying nectar. Because the result, suffering, has been extinguished, she is blissful; she is virtuous, as she no longer accumulates the causes of suffering, the nonvirtues; she is tranquil, for she has discarded the objects of abandonment, the afflictions. As she has attained great, peaceful nirvana

¹ According to Geshe Thubten Samdrub’s dictionary, *ris med mkhas pa’i zhal lung*, there are seven levels beneath the surface of the earth, though they are not explained. Taranatha’s commentary to this text lists the names, but also doesn’t explain them.

endowed with twofold purity,¹ she partakes of the peace beyond suffering. If, in connection with the method of the four remedial powers,² one wholeheartedly and without distraction recites the knowledge mantra—*TARE TÛTTARE TÛRE*, with *SOHA* at the end and *OM* at the beginning—then by the blessing and power of the mantra, the five deeds of immediate retribution,³ the ten nonvirtues,⁴ their causes (attachment, hatred, and ignorance), and their results (the sufferings of lower rebirths) will all be destroyed.

CHAK TSEL KÛN NAY KOR RAP GA WA'I
DRA YI LÛ NI RAP TÛ GEM MA
YI GEY CHÛ PAY NGAK NI KÖ PAI
RIK PA HÛNG LAY DRÖL MA NYI MA

*Homage! Thoroughly surrounded by the joyful,
She completely destroys the bodies of enemies,
Displays the sounds of the ten syllable mantra,
Liberating with awareness and HÛNG.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Barwae Oechen, “Brilliantly Blazing,” who completely destroys the power of enemies and the spells of black magicians. Red in color, she holds an utpala flower in her left hand. Upon the pistil of the flower stands a crossed vajra, the weapon that repels black magic. She is surrounded by sages and awareness holders who have accomplished mantra, samadhi, and true speech. This assembly of deities, who take tremendous joy in samadhi and benefiting beings, destroy or eliminate the enemy: evil mantras, curses, and the evil thoughts and deeds of black magicians. At the center of the wrathful lady’s heart stands *HÛNG* and “awareness,” that is the awareness mantra of ten syllables, *OM TARE TÛTTARE TÛRE SOHA*, arranged clockwise. From these syllables shine rays of light, liberating practitioners from all inner and outer obstacles, black magic, and evil mantras.

CHAK TSEL TÛ RAY SHAP NI DAP PAY
HÛNG GI NAM PAY SA PÖN NYI MA
RI RAP MAN DA RA TANG BIK CHAY
JIK TEN SÛM NAM YO WA NYI MA

*Homage! Her seed is in the aspect of HÛNG.
By stamping her TÛRE foot,
She shakes the three worlds,
And Mount Sumeru, Mandara and Bikchay⁵.*

-
- 1 That is, the two aspects of the svabhavikakaya: the innate purity of the mind and the purity that arises by removing the two kinds of adventitious obscurations.
 - 2 The four remedial powers are the power of reliance, the power of overcoming misdeeds through antidotes, the power of repentance, and the power of not repeating the misdeeds.
 - 3 The five nonvirtuous deeds that, immediately upon death, cause birth in the lowest hell realm are patricide, matricide, killing an Arhat, drawing blood from the body of a Buddha with evil intent, and causing a schism within the Sangha.
 - 4 That is, killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, speaking divisively, speaking harshly, chattering meaninglessly, covetousness, malice, and wrong view.
 - 5 Bikchay is the Tibetan name of this mountain. Its Sanskrit name and location is contested by scholars.

Here the object of homage is Tara Pagme Nonma, “Boundless Subduer,” who liberates beings from enemies, robbers, thieves and hunters. She is orange in color, like saffron. In her left hand, she holds an utpala with a stupa upon it. She stamps the ground with her swift “*TÜRE*” foot, and emits many rays of light in the form of *HÜNG* seed syllables from the *HÜNG* at her heart center, shaking the abodes of the great gods of this world, Mount Meru, Mount Mandara, Mount Bikchay, the snow mountains and so forth, the Three Worlds of the subterranean, surface, and upper worlds. She tramples underfoot enemies, robbers, thieves, bandits, and all others who do harm by the wrathful power of their misdeeds, establishing all sentient beings in the state of bliss and happiness.

CHAK TSEL LHA YI TSO YI NAM PAI
RI DAK TAK CHEN CHAK NA NAM MA
TA RA NYI JÖ PEY KYI YI GE
DÜG NAM MA LÜ PAR NI SEL MA

*Homage! She holds a rabbit-marked moon
In the aspect of a heavenly lake;
The letter PET and two times TARA
Completely clear away all poisons.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Maja Chenmo, “Great Peahen,” who protects from and cures every kind of poison. White as snow, she holds an open utpala in her left hand. Upon it rests a brilliant, vast moon, like a heavenly lake of nectar, marked with a rabbit, emitting cool rays of light. By uttering *PET* and *TARA* twice—that is, by reciting the mantra, *OM TARE TÛTTARE TÜRE SARVA BIKHA TARA PET SOHA*—poisons that enter the body by contact or ingestion, poisons made of mixed substances, poisons that work just by one’s seeing them, and every other kind of poison are eliminated. The cause of all poisons is the afflictions and self-grasping, profound emptiness the antidote that pacifies them.

CHAK TSEL LHA YI TSOK NAM GYEL PO
LHA TANG MI AM CHI YI TEN MA
KÜN NAY GO CHA GA WAY JI KYI
TSÖ TANG MI LAM NGEN PA SEL MA

*Homage! The gods, their king,
And the kinnara honor her.
By all means she dispels strife and nightmares
With the armor of joy and splendor.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Mipham Gyalmo, “Invincible Queen,” who dispels conflicts and nightmares. Her color is white. She holds a white parasol. The chief of the gods of the desire realm and the form realm—Brahma, Indra, and so on—others such as mountain gods; gods of wood and water; gods of the sky; and the king of the kinnara all honor her, the crown of their heads bowed down to her feet. The protective armor one gains by such means as meditating on her form, supplicating her, and reciting her mantra brings joy, or goodness. This causes splendor, or power, to manifest, eliminating the conflicts and

evil thoughts and deeds of enemies, as well as nightmares and evil omens.

CHAK TSEL NYI MA DA WA GYAY PAI
CHEN NYI PO LA Ö RAB SEL MA
HA RA NYI JÖ TÛT TA RA YI
SHIN TÛ DRAK PÖ RIM NAY SEL MA

*Homage! She whose two wide eyes shine
With the radiance of the sun and moon
Clears away fierce epidemics
By uttering HARA twice and TÛTTARE.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Ritroma, “Tara of the Mountain Retreat,” who dispels epidemic diseases. She is orange in color. In her hand is an open utpala flower, upon which stands a vessel filled with medicinal nectar for the dispelling of diseases. Her right eye, of the nature of the sun, sends forth hot, blazing rays of light, which burn up disease. Her left eye, of the nature of the full moon, sends forth brilliant, cooling rays of light (which are also nectar), which pacify epidemics and heat. She utters *HARA* twice and *TÛTTARE*; that is, she recites the mantra *OM TARE TÛTTARE TÛRE NAMA TARE MANO HARA HÛNG HARA SOHA*, curing severe diseases difficult to cure by medicine or other means.

CHAK TSEL DAY NYI SÛM NAM KÖ PAY
SHI WAY TÛ TANG YANG DAK DEN MA
DÖN TANG RO LANG NÖ CHIN TSOK NAM
JOM PA TÛ RE RAP CHOK NYI MA

*Homage! Adorned with three suchnesses,
Thoroughly endowed with the power of pacification—
TÛRE!—the supreme mother
Destroys the throngs of demons, vetalas and yakshas.*

Here the object of homage is Tara Oser Chenma, “Endowed with Light,” who redeems the life-force of the sick. She is white in color. Her left hand forms the mudra of giving refuge and holds an utpala flower. Upon the flower sits the auspicious golden fish. At the three places of her body, speech and mind—her heart, throat and crown—dwell the seeds of body, speech and mind of all the Tathagatas: a white *OM*, a red *AH*, and a blue *HÛNG*. These three syllables send forth rays of light, thereby liberating the faithful from harm to their body, speech or mind; external obstructions inflicted by beings with or without form; internal illness and imbalance of the elements; and the secret obstacles of dualistic grasping and the afflictions. The goddess is not only completely invested with the power to pacify these states; just by their praying to her, she is able to summon back the life-force of the sick which was stolen by hosts of spirits, yakshas, or vetalas and destroy their evil thoughts and deeds. *TÛRE* means swiftness; Tara's compassion and enlightened activity of benefiting sentient beings are as fast as lightning. Her great love for the faithful and for all sentient beings is greater than that of a mother for her only child. I pay homage to Tara, the great lady of supreme love and compassion!

TSA WAY NGAK KYI TÖ PA DI TANG
CHAK TSEL WA NI NYI SHÜ TSA CHIK

*This is the root mantra and praise
And twenty-one part homage.*

This verse is a summary of the text—the root mantra together with the praise in twenty-one verses of homage, which praises the different Taras who embody twenty-one different enlightened activities.

The lantern of the former sages' speech, accompanied
By them who have the net of discernment's light
Pull well the golden chariot of altruism
To clear the darkness from the minds of devotees.

This commentary on the praises to the twenty-one Taras, *The Glorious Bestower of All Desires*, was composed by the one called Tsulnam, an expounder of the Dharma in this final age who has devotion to the Noble Lady. By the virtue of composing it, may all beings attain the state of the swift and heroic Mother of the Conquerors.

༄༅། །སྒོལ་མའི་མཛུལ་བཞི་ཚོག་ཚོགས་གཉིས་སྟོང་པོའི་
འགྲེལ་བ་ཚོགས་གཉིས་རྒྱ་མཚོར་འདུག་པའི་
གྲུ་གཟེངས་བཞུགས་སོ།།

A Ship Sailing the Ocean of the Two Accumulations

*A Commentary on The Essence of the Two Accumulations,
The Tara Ritual of Four Mandalas*

by Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche

OM SVASTI

I bow at the feet of Holy Arya Tara.
With the merest dawning of your image
On the clean face of the pure mind's mirror,
You grant all accomplishments and siddhis.

For devotees of this profound sadhana of Arya Tara,
The Mandala, Essence of the Two Accumulations,
Ushered by the dawn-break of the thought of helping others,
The sun of Tara's elegant teachings here will rise.

This sadhana of Queen Mother Arya Tara, the embodiment of the enlightened activity of all the conquerors of the three times is based on the mandala ritual and is an unsurpassed method for purification and amassing the two Accumulations. There are a great many practitioners with devotion for this sadhana, commonly known as the “The Tara Ritual of Four Mandalas.” With their benefit in mind, I will write a short word commentary in three sections: the preparation, the main body of practice, and the conclusion.

I. Preparation

It is best if you have already received an empowerment specifically for Tara. If not, it is enough if you have other secret mantra empowerments and samaya. You should also have gone for refuge to the Three Jewels and purified your mind through renunciation and bodhicitta. Moreover, as the tantras say, you should “arrange the place, the companions, and the materials, then accomplish the practice in secret.”

Similarly, *The Adhyasaya Sutra* says:

Move to a distance of one hundred leagues
From places of distraction and dispute.
Never spend a moment in places
Where the afflictions flourish.

Therefore, for the beginner, the place of practice should not increase the strength of afflictions such as busyness, distraction, attachment, aversion and agitation. It is best to stay in places blessed by buddhas

and bodhisattvas, or else in solitary places or mountain hermitages graced by past gurus, scholars, and siddhas. You should stay in a solitary, clean, pleasant place that augments your practice of virtue, learning, reflection, meditation, and so on.

The Time

The first half of each of the first months of the four seasons,
Will bring auspiciousness, virtue, and goodness.
The full moon, new moon, and the eighth day
Will bring good omens and increase accomplishment.

The benefits of virtuous activities are greater during the first half of the first month of each season, on the four holy days of the Conqueror¹, on the eighth and fifteenth days of the month, and on the new moon. On these auspicious dates and days of favorable astrological influences you will easily attain virtue, good fortune, the accomplishment of your tutelary² deity, and siddhis. If you are practicing in order to pacify obstacles, diseases, and evil spirits, you should do so as they arise. If your purpose is to influence a matter of great importance, you should do the practice in the days preceding it. It also brings immeasurable benefit to recite this sadhana at random times or as a continuous, regular practice.

Companions

The Summary of Sutras states, “Good disciples, respectful to their masters, should always rely on their learned gurus. Why? Because they will thereby gain the qualities of wisdom.” Therefore, your spiritual companions should be gurus and spiritual friends with pure conduct, faith, and samaya, untainted by deceptiveness, anger, and jealousy. They should be peaceful and mild, with an attitude of wanting to benefit others; they should have great faith and devotion to the pure Dharma. Your companions should also have devotion and respect for the guru and the tutelary deities. Their view and conduct should be in harmony with your own.

Materials

Clean your place of practice and make it pleasant. At first, if you have them, arrange representations of the Buddha's body, speech, and mind as a general support and, in particular, a statue or painting of Tara of good quality and correct proportions that has been consecrated. You should place on your altar a mandala made from precious metal, such as gold, silver, or copper, with a heap of grains. Although in this ritual of four mandala offerings it's said that one needs four mandalas, one for the Three Jewels in general and three to offer to Tara, one mandala will suffice for the practice. You should pleasantly

1 First is the Display of Miracles, celebrated from the first to the fifteenth of the second lunar month. Second is the birth, enlightenment, and parinirvana of the Buddha Shakyamuni, the fifteenth of the fourth lunar month. Third is the turning of the wheel of Dharma, the sixth of the sixth lunar month. Fourth is the Buddha's descent from Tushita heaven, the twenty-second of the ninth lunar month.

2 Tibetan: *yi dam*

and neatly arrange a *kardum* (a round, white torma made of the three whites¹ and the three sweets²), drinking water, water for washing feet, flowers, incense, butter lamps, scented water, food, musical instruments, and so on—whatever you can get. Likewise, collect other offerings, such as a parasol, victory banner, canopy, purification water, and grains to toss. As this practice is according to kriya tantra, you should bathe and keep things tidy and clean, if possible. If not, you should practice in the early part of the day when you have not yet been tainted by meat or alcohol.

II. The Main Practice

Refuge

First you go for refuge with a single-minded attitude of faith and devotion. The gateway to all Buddhist paths is refuge. Particularly in the Mahayana tradition, the root of the path is the generation of bodhicitta. Therefore, in the beginning you should go for refuge and generate bodhicitta.

In the space before me is the Holy Lady manifest.

Firmly believing that Tara is really there, envision the objects of refuge as follows. In the space before you, in the center of clouds of offerings, rainbow light, and flowers, upon a lotus and a full moon disc, imagine that the essence of all the objects of refuge is manifest in the aspect of the Holy Lady Arya Tara. The embodiment of love and compassion, she is beautiful with a turquoise radiance. She is adorned with various ornaments and her lovely face bears a smile. She bears witness to your taking refuge. It is the nature of things that if one envisions the buddhas with single-minded faith and devotion, they will actually come. As mentioned in the sutras, “The Lord of Sages will always remain before whosoever turns her mind towards him.”

Therefore, leading all other sentient beings before the refuge Arya Tara, with tremendous devotion, go for refuge with your three doors: prostrate respectfully with your body, supplicate respectfully with your speech, and respectfully give rise to faith with your mind.

*Namo! I and all sentient beings go for refuge
To the Holy Lady, Three Jewels' embodiment.*

These lines represent actually going for refuge. *Namo* is a Sanskrit term meaning reverence or prostration. Since you go for refuge reverently you must know whom you are revering—that is, you must identify the objects of refuge. The common objects of refuge are known as the Three Precious Jewels: the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha. In the Vajrayana path of secret mantra we add to these the Three Roots: the guru, the tutelary deity, and the dakinis. You agree to go for refuge along with all beings of the six realms by saying, “From now until we attain enlightenment, we go for refuge to the Holy Arya Tara, complete embodiment of the host of deities of the Three Roots.” Moreover, with an attitude of complete trust and surrender, you should think, “From now on, whatever happens, good or bad, happy or sad, I will

1 Milk, curd, and butter.

2 Sugar, molasses, and honey.

neither take refuge nor place my hopes in anyone but you, Arya Tara.”

Generally, regarding the Three Jewels, you go for refuge to the Buddha as the teacher who shows you the path to attaining freedom, to the Dharma as the actual path to attaining freedom, and to the Sangha as the friends who help you attain freedom. That is because the Three Jewels are infallible, respectively, as the teacher of the authentic path, the path to freedom, and the friends who help you attain freedom; no one else has the ability to usher you to liberation. You take refuge until you attain the state of buddhahood. As for why, you do so in order that all sentient beings, yourself and others, once freed from the fears of samsara, may attain the ultimate liberation. The purpose and benefit of taking refuge are that it is the entrance gate to the Buddhist path. Lord Atisha said, “Refuge distinguishes the Buddhist from the non-Buddhist.” Refuge is also the foundation for all vows and the root of all paths to freedom. Thus, by taking refuge, you are counted as a Buddhist and will be protected and nurtured by the Three Jewels. Nor will you be beset by obstacles, but will set out on the path to freedom.

Bodhicitta

*Having given rise to bodhicitta of
Aspiration, I will enter the path profound.*

These two lines represent the generation of bodhicitta, the mind of enlightenment. Here, the meaning of the generation of the mind of supreme enlightenment is the motivation that thinks, “In order to place all sentient beings, my fathers and mothers, in the state of everlasting happiness, buddhahood, I will practice the profound path of Tara's sadhanas.” The meaning of the term “bodhicitta” is explained in Maitreya's *Ornament of Realization*: “Bodhicitta is to want complete, perfect enlightenment for the sake of others.” Therefore bodhicitta is the mind that wishes to attain the state of buddhahood for the sake of other beings. There are two kinds of bodhicitta: aspirational bodhicitta and engaged bodhicitta. Of these two, I have been referring of aspirational bodhicitta. Engaged bodhicitta is not just about striving for buddhahood for the sake of other sentient beings, but also about accomplishing the actual paths through practice. Another way of explaining this is that while aspirational bodhicitta is a kindhearted attitude focused on others, actually accomplishing their benefit is engaged bodhicitta. Bodhicitta is not just the point of entry to the way of Mahayana, it is also the foundation of the Mahayana paths. It is also said that bodhicitta differentiates the Mahayana from the Hinayana. All the roots of virtue embraced by bodhicitta increase without ever being exhausted. They become the cause of buddhahood and bring complete benefit to others. Thus, as it has countless benefits, it is essential to practice bodhicitta.

The Seven-Branch Prayer

1. Homage

*With total faith I pay homage
To Holy Arya Tara and
All the conquerors and their heirs
In ten directions and three times.*

You and all sentient beings are the ones paying homage. They to whom you pay homage are the

twenty-one Taras, all gurus, and the conquerors together with their heirs that dwell in all times, in all places, in all directions. The ten directions are the four cardinal directions, the four ordinal directions, above, and below. The three times are past, present, and future, but for brevity's sake we say, "in all times, in all places, in all directions." You prostrate single-mindedly with total faith and devotion to the objects of homage. The "total" in "total faith" refers to the manner in which you pay homage: with all three doors of body, speech and mind. Homage is the antidote to the affliction of pride.

2. Offering

*I make offerings, real and mental,
Of flowers, incense, butter lamps,
Of perfumes, food, music, and more;
Noble Assembly, please accept them.*

You should offer whatever you may have, such as flowers, incense, and so forth. Make imagined offerings as well of beautiful flowers, sweet-smelling incense, radiant butter lamps, delicious foods, and melodious music—offerings so vast they pervade the totality of space. Mainly offer these, the objects of the five senses, but also offer everything in the whole billionfold universe to the twenty-one Arya Taras, thinking, "Please accept them out of your great compassion so that I and all sentient beings may complete the accumulations." Offering is the antidote to the affliction of miserliness.

3. Confession

*I confess all misdeeds I have done,
My mind beneath the power of afflictions,
From time beginningless until right now,
The ten nonvirtues and five immediates.¹*

Before the supreme, holy field of merit, you and all other sentient beings confess the ten non-virtues, which you have been committing since beginningless time—the three non-virtues of the body (killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct), the four non-virtues of speech (lying, divisive speech, harsh speech, and meaningless chatter), the three non-virtues of the mind (covetousness, malice, and wrong view); also confess the five actions of immediate retribution (patricide, matricide, killing an arhat, creating schism in the Sangha, and drawing a buddha's blood with bad intent) and afflictions like attachment, anger, pride, ignorance, hatred, jealousy, and so forth. In short, you confess all non-virtuous deeds, which are products of the afflictions. When you confess your misdeeds with the four powers and a strong sense of shame and regret, they will be purified. It is said, "The one good quality of misdeeds is that they will be purified if you confess them." Confession is an antidote to misdeeds in general, but mainly to hatred.

4. Rejoicing

*I rejoice in all merits and virtues
Collected in the three times by*

¹ The five deeds of immediate retribution.

*Hearers, solitary buddhas,
Bodhisattvas, and common beings.*

Before Arya Tara and the field of merit, rejoice in all the merit of others and in the results of their virtue, the happiness of higher birth and the highest good¹. Rejoice also in all the qualities and merits of the hearers, solitary buddhas, and bodhisattvas—noble beings who have actualized the results of the three vehicles. Rejoice wholeheartedly in all the virtuous causes which bring about joyful results for ordinary beings, their virtues and merits in all three times, their abundance and wealth, their bodies and health. In short, rejoice in all their goodness and good qualities.

As for the benefits of rejoicing:

If, abandoning the wicked mind of jealousy,
You rejoice with heartfelt gladness
On hearing of others' virtuous deeds,
You will gain merit equal to theirs, it is said.

Rejoicing is the antidote to jealousy. There is no good reason to be jealous and no benefit comes from it. It not only makes you unhappy, it also causes unhappiness for others. Be careful, or else jealousy will cause much suffering for you and others in lives to come.

5. Prayer to Turn the Wheel of Dharma

*In accordance with the different minds
And mentalities of sentient beings,
Please turn the wheel of Dharma of
The greater, lesser, and common vehicles.*

Thus pray that the buddhas, bodhisattvas, gurus, and spiritual friends turn the wheel of Dharma of the Mahayana and the Hinayana, giving every kind of teaching specifically according to the dispositions, interests, and different mentalities of the beings who are to be tamed.

6. Prayer Not to Pass into Nirvana

*I beseech you, do not pass into
Nirvana until samsara empties out,
But with compassion look on beings who
Are drowning in this sea of suffering.*

Thus beseech the buddhas, bodhisattvas, gurus, and spiritual friends who wish to pass into nirvana not to do so until samsara empties out, but to look with compassion on you and others who, tormented by the three sufferings, drown in the ocean of samsara, and to place you all in higher rebirths and the state of the highest good.

¹ The highest good or *nges legs* refers to states of liberation and omniscience.

7. Dedication

*May whatever merit I have gathered
All become the cause of enlightenment,
And, without any more delay, may I
Become a glorious guide for wanderers.*

“Whatever merit I have gathered” means the virtues that come from gathering merit and purifying obscurations by means of the seven branch prayer, which you have just recited. This merit stands for the collection of all the merit that you and everyone else have gathered throughout the three times. May all these roots of virtue become the cause of perfect enlightenment, and, without any more delay, may you become the protector, refuge, and guide who leads all sentient beings on the perfect path. Having attained the state of buddhahood, may you perform the benefit of beings for as long as space endures.

Offering

After completing the accumulations through the seven-branch prayer, bless the offerings with the mantra of the wrathful Amrita Kundali:

OM BENZA AMRITA KÜNDALI HANA HANA HÜNG PET

Then recite:

OM SO BHA WA SHÜD DHO SAR WA DHARMA SO BHA WA SHÜD DHO HAM

Imagining that this mantra purifies the impure stains of greed and clinging to phenomena as real. Then sprinkling water, all outer and inner phenomena are purified into emptiness.

Then:

*This place becomes the Lotus Arrangement Field
Adorned with shapes in measureless array.
Formed by samadhi, substances divine
Turn into thought-unfathomed offerings.*

From the state of emptiness, this outer place, being no ordinary dwelling place or environment, is Arya Tara's pure land Lotus Arrangement of Great Bliss and its celestial mansion. Its shapes and ornamentation are marvelous; their measure and limits cannot be grasped by the mind. Imagine that drinking water, water for washing feet, flowers, incense, butter lamps, scented water, food, music, and so forth; all untainted, divine offerings produced by samadhi; the objects of the five senses as well; the eight auspicious symbols; the seven royal possessions; parasols; and victory banners—offerings of all the riches and wonders there are whatsoever in samsara or nirvana—completely fill all directions, places, realms, and all of space.

Then recite the offering mantra.

OM BENZA ARGHAM / PA DYAM / PÜK PE / DHÜ PE / A LO KAY / GEN DHE / NA
WI DYA / SHAB DA AH HÜNG

Then:

OM BENZA SAPARANA KAM

The meaning of this mantra is “May the clouds of offerings, drinking water, etc. never be exhausted.”

At the beginning of offering the four mandalas, you offer the first one to the Three Jewels in general. Just as with the homage and previous offerings, the object of the mandala offering is the field of merit. Recite the evocation:

All gurus, conquerors, and their heirs of the ten directions and four times are in the space before me. BENZA SA MA DZA.

The ten directions are the four cardinal directions, the four ordinal directions, above, and below. The four times are the conventional three times of the past, present, and future, plus the ultimate time—that is, the time of evenness that, by virtue of emptiness, the ultimate mode of being, is beyond all time. As you utter *BENZA SAMADZA*, the mantra of evocation, all the gurus and spiritual friends throughout the four times, who show us the faults to abandon and the qualities to accept; the buddhas who are victorious over the afflictions, the two obscurations, and the four maras; the heirs of the buddhas, the bodhisattvas; and the hearers and solitary buddhas appear in the space before you. Having uttered the mantra with single-minded faith and yearning, recite:

*Protectors of all sentient beings without exception,
Deities who overcome the maras and their hosts,
You who know all things whatever as they are,
Pray come here with your retinues, Oh Blessed Ones!*

PEMA KA MA LA YA SA TAM

For the benefit of others, the buddhas are the refuge and protectors of all sentient beings without exception, for they have completely abandoned the partiality of closeness to friends and superiors and distance from enemies and inferiors. For their own benefit, they are supreme deities who destroyed all the maras—that is the afflictions, self-grasping, the two obscurations, and the hosts of maras. The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, know precisely the mode of being and mode of appearance of all things, of all phenomena whatsoever. With single-minded faith and yearning, pray that they come to the place where you are making offerings. Thus praying, you invite the buddhas. Then recite, “*PEMA KAMALA YA SATAM*,” which means “Please stay here on this lotus throne.” Imagine that the conquerors come to the space in front of you and sit on lotuses and other plush, luxurious thrones. Then, in their presence recite the seven-branch prayer to amass the accumulations.

First you pay homage:

*With purity in body, speech and mind
I pay homage to all the lions of men,*

*However many exist in the three times
In all the worlds that are in ten directions.*

“In all worlds that are in ten directions” means limitless. “In the three times” refers to the buddhas who came in the past, those who will come in the future, and those who are presently coming. “Lions of men” means that just as the lion is the supreme king of the animals, the buddhas are supreme among humans. “However many exist” means that you respectfully pay homage with body, speech, and mind to every buddha whatsoever.

Then pay homage specifically with your body:

*By virtue of my aspiration to good conduct,
May all the conquerors come clearly to my mind.
I pay homage to them all, prostrating with
As many bodies as there are atoms in the world.*

Here you pay homage to the buddhas, who are the conquerors of the maras, afflictions, and so on. “By virtue of my aspiration to good conduct” means by virtue of the bodhisattvas' conduct and aspirations. By that power you will see the conquerors clearly; alternately, imagine or believe that they are actually before you. Then, emanating or imagining bodies equal in number to the atoms of all worlds, prostrate sincerely before each of them.

Then pay homage with your mind:

*I imagine the assembled buddhas,
As many as are atoms, on each atom,
Abiding in the midst of all their heirs,
The dharmadhatu filled with conquerors.*

In the dharmata, buddhas equal in number to all the particles in existence, both fine and coarse, are gathered on each particle. That they are equal in number to all particles means that there are countless buddhas. Imagine that the buddhas abiding amidst their heirs, the bodhisattvas, fill the infinite, measureless dharmadhatu. With your mind, pay homage to them with confident faith.

Finally pay homage through speech:

*I proclaim the conquerors' qualities
And sing the praises of the bliss-gone ones
With all the sounds that fill an ocean of
Diverse tunes, an endless sea of praise.*

Here you are paying homage with speech to the buddhas, who have obtained the result, the state of sugata, or bliss-gone one, by relying on the cause, the path of the ones gone to bliss. With a vast ocean of gentle melodies, sweet voices, and endless sounds, proclaim the profound qualities of all the conquerors and sing the sea of praises of all the bliss-gone ones.

The second branch, offering, has two aspects: ordinary offerings and extraordinary offerings. Concerning the ordinary offerings the text says:

*I make offerings to the conquerors
Of exquisite flowers, precious garlands,
Cymbals, unguents, and fine parasols,
The best of lamps, the finest incenses;*

*I make offerings to the conquerors
Of all the finest clothing, fragrances,
And powders piled up to Meru's heights
And in the most resplendent of arrangements.*

Here you are offering to the assembly of the conquerors and their heirs beautiful flowers, precious garlands, sweet music, aromatic perfumes, parasols made from all kinds of fine materials, bright lamps, fragrant incense of both naturally occurring and prepared varieties and so forth. You also offer beautifully colored, fine, soft clothing, unguents of various sweet smells, and piles of powder made from saffron and sandalwood, as high as Mount Meru. Give all of these excellent offerings to the conquerors and their heirs in clean, pleasant, and beautiful arrangements.

Then, concerning the extraordinary offering, it says:

*For all the conquerors, I imagine
These vast and incomparable offerings.
By virtue of my faith in wholesome conduct,
I prostrate and make offerings to them.*

The offerings created through the aspirations and samadhi of the bodhisattvas, heirs of the conquerors, are the best of offerings. These offerings are incomparable because no other offerings can match them. Therefore, they extend unceasing throughout all directions and times. Pay homage and offer this vastness to all the conquerors through the power of your devotion and your faith in wholesome conduct.

The third branch concerns the confession of misdeeds:

*Whatever misdeeds I have done
With body, speech, or mind due to
Attachment, hatred, or delusion,
I confess them, every one.*

Urged on by the three poisons—the cause, the afflictions of attachment, hatred, and delusion—whatever misdeeds of body, speech, or mind that you yourself have done, forced others to do, or rejoiced in others doing: confess them all, each and every one.

The fourth branch is rejoicing:

*I rejoice in all the merit of
The ten directions' conquerors, their heirs,
Of lone buddhas, learners, no-more-learners,
And every wanderer without exception.*

With an attitude of gladness and enthusiasm, you should rejoice in all the happiness, virtue, and merit of all beings whatsoever—of the conquerors dwelling in the ten directions; of the bodhisattvas, heart children of the buddhas; of the buddhas' speech-children: those arhats who are solitary buddhas and those who are hearers, and those who are learning and those who are no longer learning; and of wanderers or ordinary beings.

The fifth branch is the request to turn the wheel of Dharma:

*Lamps of all the worlds of ten directions,
You protectors who, without desire,
Gained buddhahood by stages—I request
You all to turn the matchless Dharma wheel.*

The conquerors are the lamps that perfectly show the path to beings in all the worlds of the ten directions, who are obscured by the dense darkness of ignorance about what to accept or reject. Request or supplicate all the protectors—the buddhas or blessed ones who traveled the path to enlightenment in stages and, without desire, gained the state of buddhahood—to turn the unsurpassed Dharma wheel.

The sixth branch is praying to the buddhas not to pass into nirvana:

*With palms conjoined, I pray to you who wish
To show your passing to nirvana, stay
For beings' benefit and happiness
For eons many as atoms in the world.*

For the temporary benefit and ultimate happiness of all this world's wanderers to be tamed, press your palms together and with single-minded faith and yearning pray to those buddhas and bodhisattvas who wish to display their passing into nirvana not to do so, but to remain for eons equal in number to the particles in the world.

The seventh and final branch is dedication:

*Whatever meager virtue I have gathered
Through homage, offering, confession, and
Rejoicing, requesting, and prayer—every virtue
I dedicate for full enlightenment.*

Here you dedicate whatever meager roots of virtue you have gained through homage to the great conquerors, offering, confession of misdeeds, rejoicing in the merit of others, entreating the buddhas to turn the wheel of Dharma, praying that they to remain and not pass into nirvana, and so on. This represents all the merit accumulated in the three times by yourself and others. As for why, you dedicate the merit for the sake of winning the state of complete enlightenment. The way to dedicate merit is with the wisdom of emptiness that is pure of the three spheres.

General Mandala Offering

Now that you have made the offering of the seven branches, you make a mandala offering to the Three Jewels in general.

OM AH HUNG

Having been blessed in terms of purification, transformation, and increase¹ by this life-force mantra of body, speech, and mind, offer the following.

*I and sentient beings without count,
Having emanated constantly
All our bodies, wealth, and gathered virtue,
The four continents, Meru, sun and moon,
The thought-unfathomed wealth of gods and humans,
Samantabhadra's massive offering clouds,*

You and all countless beings offer your bodies, which you have grasped as *I*; your wealth and gathered virtue, which you have grasped as *mine*; the four continents—Purvavideha in the east, Jambudvīpa in the south, Aparagodaniya in the west, and Uttarakuru in the north—the billion islands, the Mount Meru of the great billionfold universe, the Sea of Enjoyment, and the sun and moon. You offer the inexhaustible wealth, fortune, and glory of the gods, nagas, and humans. Offer also the hard to fathom, cloud-like offerings of Samantabhadra.

As for those to whom you make this vast and ceaselessly emanated mandala offering:

*To the Three Jewels, the precious Three Roots, and
The sea of dharmapalas and wealth deities,*

The precious Three Jewels are the Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha. The Three Roots are the guru, root of blessings; the tutelary deity, root of siddhi; and the dakinis, root of activity. The ocean of deities is the gods, nagas, etc. on the side of virtue, the protectors who guard the Dharma, and the wealth deities who grant the siddhi of inexhaustible riches.

Concerning the manner in which you make offerings:

*We offer them respectfully and always.
This massive gathering of merit finished,
May the light of primordial wisdom grow.*

OM GÜRÜ DEWA DAKINI SARWA RATNA MANDALA PÜDZA MEGHA AH HÜNG

You make offerings faithfully and respectfully with body, speech, and mind always, without ceasing. As you have now utterly completed the vast accumulation of merit—the method—may the light of the

¹ Here the meanings of purification, transformation, and increase can be illustrated by the example of a flower. The offering of the flower is purified by *OM*, which cleanses any dirt or other mundane impurities as well as your own grasping at the intrinsic reality of the flower. When increased by *AH*, the offering multiplies limitlessly. The flower is transformed by *HUNG*, and so becomes immaculate, the nature of stainless primordial wisdom. (from private conversation with Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche)

accumulation of primordial wisdom grow. In other words, in dependence on the immense gathering of merit you've amassed by offering the mandala, may the light of the primordial wisdom that realizes the mode of being of phenomena grow in your mindstream. Then, after reciting the mantra of the mandala offering, you should offer the mandala and toss some grains in the air. Generally speaking, the mandala offering is easy to do and yields huge benefit. It is the best way to complete the great accumulation of merit quickly. The sutras say, "Because they have merit, all their wishes are fulfilled." Similarly, if you strive in the practice of the mandala, you will have longevity, merit, glory, wealth, power, and fame in this life. What's more, experience and realization, love and compassion will be born in your mindstream, and in future lives, you will have the short-term pleasure and comfort of the gods and humans in the higher realms. Then, gradually, with greater and greater realizations on the grounds and paths, you will at last obtain unimagined qualities, the matchless result of the two accumulations—the form body adorned with the marks of a buddha and the dharma body, which is the very essence of stainless primordial wisdom.

Now pray before the supreme field of merit for the fulfillment of your goals.

*NAMO
Buddha, Dharma, Sangha, and
Guru, deity, dakinis,
Protectors, wealth gods, treasure lords—
From the one primordial wisdom essence,
The nature, unimpeded, shows protean forms.
Wondrous compassion and activity!
To you, refuge and guardians of all beings,
Embodiments of love and wisdom, I
Pay homage and in earnest go for refuge.
I offer you my body and my wealth
And pray that you compassionately guard
Myself and endless beings at all times.
Please pacify disease and injury,
Increase longevity and merit, and
Bless me to accomplish all my wishes
In accordance with the holy Dharma.*

Namo means homage. The Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha are the Three Jewels. The guru shows you what to accept and what to reject, so you should know that he has the supreme qualities of wisdom and love. The so-called tutelary deity or *yidam* is also referred to as the personal deity in whose body the buddhas and bodhisattvas have arisen. The dakinis are companions in accomplishing the Dharma, yoginis endowed with mundane and supramundane realization and power who accomplish activities. The protectors who guard the holy Dharma and delight in virtue; the gathering of yaksha wealth gods who grant the siddhi of wealth, and the treasure lords who guard hidden Dharma texts, articles, and wealth are all one within the essence, dharmadhatu, the primordial wisdom of suchness. Their nature or aspect is unimpeded, and they are endowed with supreme compassion, power, and enlightened activity, which display all kinds of form bodies.

Therefore pay homage and go for refuge wholeheartedly to them who are the refuge and protectors of all beings, who possess the wisdom of knowledge and measureless love and compassion. Offering your

own and others' bodies, wealth, and roots of virtue, pray one-pointedly, "Always protect limitless sentient beings, especially my sponsors and all those connected to me, never letting them leave the sheltering wall of your compassion. Please quell all adverse circumstances, obstacles, and harm, and increase all favorable circumstances such as longevity and merit, wealth and fortune, glory and wisdom, faith and compassion. Please grant all my wishes without exception. Please grant me the blessing of accomplishment consistent with the Dharma, separate from bad karma and non-virtuous thoughts and deeds."

Then you make the three mandala offerings to Holy Tara and recite the praise. To start with, meditate on yourself as Holy Tara. When giving rise to the divine body, with your mind you envision that your body is not an ordinary body as it is now, but the body of the deity. There are two ways of doing this meditation. One is to meditate on the seed syllable, throne, and so forth in stages. The other is to create the visualization all at once, in an instant. Here we will follow the simultaneous method.

First, purify your reification of the aggregates, dwelling place, and so on into emptiness. If this focal point of emptiness is stable, it will be very easy to meditate on the body of the deity. Although kriya tantra has the generation of the deity's body, it is said that this is not an authentic generation stage practice. But I will explain the general idea a bit here. In the context of meditation, the generation stage is typically explained in terms of three kinds of purity. The first is called "firm pride." Whichever deity you are meditating on, firm pride is to think, when envisioning it, that you actually *are* that deity. The purity of "vivid aspects" is to envision clearly the deity's face, hands, and jewelry all together without getting them mixed up. Last of all, "perfect recall" means that once you know the reasons and need for all the jewelry and attire on the deity's body, you stay mindful of their significance. For example, deities of wrathful aspect are for taming cruel and hateful beings, animal-headed ones are the antidote that tames deluded beings, etc. You should know which of these are meant for taming which kinds of beings. Even if you cannot get the face, hands, and so on of the deity very clear, it is still appropriate to meditate with conviction¹. The point of meditating on the divine body is not just to receive blessings, it is mainly to purify from your mindstream your afflictions and attachment to the appearance of the ordinary world and its inhabitants, as well as to accomplish the Buddha's future form body.

*Instantly upon recalling I
Appear in Holy Tara's form complete.
A green-hued TAM is on the moon at my heart.
Then from the TAM spread boundless rays of light,
Inviting to the space in front of me
The twenty-one Arya emanations
And an oceanic cloud of Jewels.*

After purifying all phenomena of subject and object into emptiness, then, from that state of emptiness, as soon as you recall her, you instantly arise as the completely perfect body of Holy Tara. Tara, the embodiment of all the enlightened activities of the Victorious Ones of the three times, is green, the color of all-accomplishing wisdom. She has one face and two arms. Her lovely face is smiling and the sweet smell of utpala flowers wafts from her mouth. Her right hand forms the mudra of supreme generosity, for she protects sentient beings who have faith and pray to her from conflict and distress—from all fears. Her left hand, resting at her heart, holds the stem of an utpala with the thumb and ring finger; its petals in full

¹ That is, conviction, in the case of self-generation practice, that you really are the deity or, in the case of front visualization, that the deity is really there before you.

bloom rest in front of her ear. Her body, sixteen years of age, is adorned with the major and minor marks. She sits in the charmed posture¹. A pair of round, full breasts adorns her chest. She wears all kinds of jewelry—earrings, a crown, etc.—a blue upper garment, and skirts of various kinds of silk. Her black hair gleams with oil. She sits with legs uncrossed; her right leg extends forward a bit, while her left is drawn in. Behind her is draped a vast, full, white moon. A green letter *TAM* is above the moon's seat at her heart. From it multicolored rays of light spread infinitely, their tips like bent metal hooks. With these tips they pull into the space before you the twenty-one Holy Taras as well as the buddhas and bodhisattvas of all directions and times—an ocean of the Three Jewels like a thick cloud bank.

Then pray with single-minded faith and yearning:

TAM
In the dharma body's unborn, lucid sphere,
In the Arya's unimpeded wisdom body,
Dawns an illusory web for taming beings
Come hither to me! ARYA TARE DZAH!

TAM is the life-force mantra of Tara's name. It has the sense of calling out, “Oh Tara!” From the ultimate, unborn dharmadhatu, the sphere of the dharma body, Tara emerges in her unimpeded, compassionate, conventional form body or wisdom body², the union of appearances and emptiness, an illusory web to tame beings according to their inclinations, dispositions, and so forth. Call on the wisdom body in the same form as you were meditating on earlier, praying for it to come to the place where you are. *ARYA TARE DZAH* is meant as an invitation to Tara. If you pray in this way to the personal deities, calling their names with single-minded faith and yearning, it is their nature to come, just as, for example, your friends will come quickly if you call their names.

Requesting the Deities to Remain

Out of love for me and wanderers
And by the force of magical display,
Remain here, Blessed One, I pray,
For as long as I make offerings to you.
PEMA KAMALA SATAM

Pray that Arya Tara, the Blessed One, will think of you and all wandering sentient beings and, out of tremendous love and by the power of her bodhicitta, aspirations, and magical display, will stay and partake of your offerings for as long as you continue to make them so that you may perfectly complete the accumulations of merit and wisdom.

PEMA KA MA LA SATAM being a mantra of prayer to remain, when you recite it, imagine that Tara gladly remains with you.

1 One of eight moods or kinds of expression used in ancient Indian theater, the charmed posture refers to the look of someone who has just seen a comely form.

2 The wisdom body (*jnanakaya*) is the actual deity residing in her pure land, as opposed to the *samayasattva* which is the deity as whom you arise, or whom you envision before you. The point here, as the author Khenpo Tsulnam explained in private conversation, is that the form body, which is the union of appearance and emptiness, is a manifestation of the actual deity that issues from the dharma body.

General Offering

OM

*I completely fill the dharmadhatu
With Samantabhadra's cloud of offerings
Both material and mind-arisen,
And offer them to Tara and her retinue.*

*OM ARYA TARE SA PARIWARA BENZA ARGHAM / PA DYAM / PÜK PE / DHÜ PE / A
LO KAY / GEN DHE / NA WI DYA / SHAB DA TRA TI TSA SOHA*

OM means protection and blessing. Actual offerings of flowers, incense, butter lamps, and such; the entire wealth of the vessel of the outer world and its contents, sentient beings; offerings imagined and emanated with your mind—a cloud of Samantabhadra's offerings created through the power of aspiration and samadhi: All these fill the dharmadatu—that is to say, are infinite. So imagine filling all of space with them and giving them to Arya Tara and her retinue while uttering the offering mantras. As for the meaning of the mantras, *ARYA TARA* means Noble Tara. *SAPARIWARA* means “together with her retinue.” *ARGHAM* is water for drinking. *PADYAM* is bathing water, *PÜKPE* flowers, *DHÜPE* incense, *ALOKE* butter lamps, *GENDE* scented water, *NEWIDYA* food, and *SHABTA* music. *TRATITSA* means, “Please accept these offerings.”

Specific Mandala Offerings

OM AH HÜNG

*I offer you all, essence of compassion,
The wealth of three realms, vessel and its contents,
My body, all my wealth and store of virtue.
I pray you, take them and your blessings give.
OM SARWA TATHAGATA RATNA MANDALA PÜ DZA HO*

OM AH HÜNG signifies offerings pleasing to Tara's body, speech, and mind. You offer all the wealth and fortune of the outer vessel of the world and its three realms—the desire, form, and formless realms—and of the inner contents, sentient beings, to Holy Arya Tara, whose nature is wisdom and love, together with her retinue. Offer also your body, wealth, and all your gathered virtue. Pray that, accepting your offering, she will give her blessings to you and other beings out of the vast love she bears for you all. The mantra *OM SARWA TATHAGATA RATNA MANDALA PÜDZA HO* means, “Please accept and be delighted in this precious mandala which I offer to you, Thus Gone, Blessed, Holy Tara and all buddhas and bodhisattvas.”

Then, having offered the first mandala, give praise to the twenty-one Taras. There are two praises to the twenty-one Taras. The first is the king of praises, which celebrates in twenty-one homages Holy Tara's qualities of body, speech, and mind as well as her enlightened activities. The second praises the twenty-one Taras individually. As you recite the praise, keep in mind that here you are mainly praising Green Tara in twenty-one homages. Recite it twice, then make the general offering again, beginning with “*OM I*

completely fill the dharmadhatu . . .” and going through the specific offering of the mandala that begins with “*OM AH HUNG I offer you all . . .*” while understanding these verses as having the same meaning as before.

*Her right hand, in the supreme giving mudra,
Changes to the refuge-granting mudra.
Gathering beneath it, I and all
Those guarded find relief from every fear.*

Holy Tara's right hand, which is in the mudra of supreme giving, changes to the refuge-granting mudra. You and all those who are to be guarded gather there with the crowns of your heads placed beneath her hand, thereby gaining protection from all fears of fire, water, poison, weapons, sickness, evil spirits, every type of obstacle, the sufferings of samsara and those of the lower realms, and every kind of harm. Then, thinking that by receiving her protection you have found a joyful sense of relief, recite the twenty-one homage praise three more times.

Once again, recite “*OM I completely fill the dharmadhatu . . .*” and make the third mandala offering, “*OM AH HUNG I offer you all. . .*” thinking them to have the same meaning as before. Then:

*A stream of nectar flows down from her body,
And enters through my own crown and the crowns
Of all the beings under her protection,
Filling up our bodies with her blessings.*

A stream of very pure nectar, white in color, flows down from the tip of the big toe of Holy Tara's right foot. This stream, which is of the nature of blessing and compassion, falls and enters through the crown of your head and through the crowns all others under her protection. It cleanses and purifies all illnesses, spirits, misdeeds, and obscurations of the body; they leave your body and dissolve into the ground below. This nectar of blessing and compassion fills your body, and the blessings of Holy Tara's body, speech, and mind enter your mindstream. Meditating thus, recite the praise to the twenty-one Taras seven times.

The Benefits of Reciting Tara's Praises

*The learned who respect the goddess fully
When rising first at the dawn, again at dusk,
Will make this recitation from the heart
And, calling her to mind, find fearlessness.
Thereby their misdeeds will be pacified,
Thereby their lower births will be destroyed.*

With full faith and devotion for the goddess Tara, recite her praises and her mantra, not just mouthing the words but with an attitude of single-minded faith. “*When rising first at dawn, again at dusk . . . and, calling her to mind . . .*” means calling to mind her bodily aspect, her speech or mantra, and her mind or wisdom which is knowing, loving, and powerful. At dusk, recall her wrathful form, her

peaceful form at dawn. If only you call her to mind and pray to her, illnesses, spirits, untimely death, fire, water, and all such obstacles and fears of this life will be pacified, and you will be given total fearlessness. Your misdeeds, the cause of being born in lower realms in future lives, will be utterly quelled. “*Their lower births will be destroyed*” means that, from birth to birth, in future lives you will not be born in the lower realms.

*And they will quickly get empowerments
From seven times ten million conquerors
And thus accomplish greatness and proceed
Unto the final state of buddhahood.*

*Its poisons, intense and terrible are
In the environment and in beings.
All, whether eaten or even imbibed,
Are remedied through mindfulness of her.*

*The host of painful sufferings brought about
By spirits, epidemics, and poisons
Will be dispelled for others and themselves.*

Arya Tara, as well as seventy million, that is many many buddhas and bodhisattvas who come simultaneously, will quickly bless and give empowerments and prophecies to practitioners. In this current life you will have abundant common and uncommon qualities, such as long life and merit, followers and disciples, fame and glory, hearing, pondering, meditation, and so on. You will quickly proceed through the grounds and paths in stages and soon reach the state of buddhahood.

There are tremendously cruel poisons that can disrupt you from reaching this goal. The main poison is wrong view, exemplified by the afflictions that get in the way of attaining liberation and the obscurations of the knowable that get in the way of attaining omniscience. Then there are the poisons in the environment—in the water, plants, and so on. There are also poisons carried by sentient beings, such as snakes and animals with poisonous fangs, stingers, or evil spirits' poisons of sight, contact, and thought, as well as artificial poisons which are placed in food or drink. All of these poisons can be remedied by turning your mind to Tara and her mantra. Moreover, all the sufferings of pain from malignant spirits, being stricken by severe plagues, or poisons both inner and outer will be completely dispelled or eliminated. The same benefits will come to anyone else who praises or prays to Tara for the benefit of other beings.

*Reciting clearly two, three, seven times,
Who wishes for a son will have a son,
And they who wish for wealth, too, will have wealth,
Indeed, they will have all that they desire,
And obstacles will each be smashed to naught.*

In this ritual, you first recite *Twenty-One Praises to Tara* twice, later three times, and finally seven times. Other texts explain this as follows: Twice means both day and night. Three times means three times

during daytime—in the morning, noon, and afternoon—and three times at night—at dusk, midnight, and just before daybreak. Seven times means that in each of these sessions you recite the *Twenty-One Praises* seven times clearly and with single-minded faith and veneration. By praising in this way, if you are a family holder who wishes for sons, you will have sons. If you are a Dharma lineage holder who wishes for disciples, you will have disciples. If you wish for wealth and possessions, you will obtain them in abundance easily. You will, moreover, have all ultimate and short-term desires, be they good business, a husband or wife, or other such things, or else the activities of pacifying, enriching, magnetizing, and subjugating, or the common or supreme siddhis. Any new obstacles that get in the way of your desires will be annihilated, and the old ones will be smashed without remnant by Holy Tara's compassion. Because the *Twenty-One Praises* is like the wish-fulfilling jewel that achieves all purposes and because it has infinite benefits, it stands to reason that all fortunate people who wish for the welfare of themselves and others should apply themselves to reciting it with faith, conviction, enthusiasm, and effort.

Torma Offering

Next, sprinkle the torma with the purifying water and recite the mantra of the wrathful Amrita Kundali, which purifies obstacles and grants blessings.

OM BENZA AMRITA KÜNDALI HANA HANA HÜNG PET

Then recite:

OM SO BHA WA SHÜD DHO SAR WA DHARMA SO BHA WA SHÜD DHO HAM

With this mantra imagine that the torma is purified into emptiness without reference point.

*From emptiness's state the letter OM,
From OM a vessel precious, vast, supreme,
Within, the torma rises from three seeds,
Becomes the nectar of untainted wisdom.*

Meditate this way: From the state in which the torma has transformed into nonconceptual emptiness, the letter *OM* appears clearly and then becomes a vast, precious torma tray. Within this vessel the three seed syllables *OM AH HUNG* melt into light, from which arises the torma. The torma, its nature now purified, transformed, and increased, turns into the nectar of primordial wisdom.

OM AH HUNG

Utter the syllables three times, then recite the torma offering mantra thrice:

OM ARYA TARE SAPARIWARA IDAM BA LINGTA KHA KHA KHAHI KHAHI

ARYA TARE refers to Noble Tara. *SAPARIWARA* means “together with her retinue.” *IDAM BA LINGTA* means “this torma.” *KHA KHA* means “in the mouth.” *KHAHI KHAHI* means “Please accept, please accept.”

OM AKARO MÜKAM SARWA DHARMA NAM ADYA NÜT PA NAN TOT TA
OM AH HUNG PHEY SOHA

Reciting this three times, make the offering to the retinue and the guests.¹ Then pray for the fulfillment of aims.

OM
With great primordial wisdom think
Of this pure torma offering,
And having partaken of great bliss
Pray grant all siddhis entirely.

Pray, “With your mind of powerful primordial wisdom, I pray you think of this torma which I have offered to the field of merit above and given to all the guests below; be delighted with it and partake of it with great, untainted bliss. I pray that you grant me the ultimate, the supreme siddhi of the attainment of liberation and the all-knowing state. And I pray that you grant me the temporary, common siddhis: long life, merit, glory, fame, and such, the powers of pacifying, enriching, magnetizing, and subjugating.” Having thus prayed, believe that you have obtained all siddhis.

Offerings & Praise

As an expression of gratitude, make offerings and give praise.

OM ARYA TARE SA PARI WARA BENZA ARGHAM / PA DYAM / PÜK PE / DHÜ PE / A
LO KAY / GEN DHE / NA WI DYA / SHAB DA TRA TI TSA SOHA

Make offerings with drinking water, bathing water, flowers, incense, and so on.

OM
Arisen from the face of Lokeshvara
Of Amitabha's lotus family,
The Lady of all buddhas' activities—
I prostrate and give praise to Arya Tara.

Here you pay homage to Arya Tara and, mindful of her qualities, praise her who embodies the enlightened activities of all the three times' buddhas and who sprang from the tears of Avalokiteshvara, the lord and protector of all worlds, of Buddha Amitabha's lotus family of enlightened speech.

¹ Here “guests” refers to the upper guests, who are the three roots.

*I give praise with utmost faith
To them all who merit praise,
Bowing down to them with bodies
Numerous as this world's atoms.*

Moreover, envisioning emanated bodies equal in number to the atoms in all the lands of the world, bow down humbly with your three doors to the praiseworthy conquerors and their heirs in every land, direction, and time. Praise them at all times and with utmost faith.

Prayers & Aspirations

In prayer and aspiration, with ardent yearning and devotion, join your palms together:

*Holy Tara with your retinue,
Think of me with objectless compassion.
As I have prayed, bless me to achieve
My prayed-for purpose without obstacle.*

Pray that the twenty-one Holy Taras and the gathering of buddhas and bodhisattvas, though they are free from the proliferation of referential concepts, will think of you lovingly, with great kindness and compassion. Pray that they bless you to accomplish your entire purpose unhindered and in fulfillment of your wishes, just as you have prayed with single-minded faith and veneration.

Then make the aspiration for the Buddha's teachings to spread.

*May Buddha's teaching grow and spread, its holders
Know harmony, their lotus feet be firm,¹
All harmful obstacles be pacified,
And the works of teaching and practice grow.*

May the all-knowing Conqueror's precious teachings, the source of all happiness and benefit, pervade and grow in the farthest reaches of all directions. The holders of the Dharma hold the three spheres: reading the Buddha's teaching, which is the sphere of hearing and pondering; relinquishment, which is the sphere of meditation; and action, which is the sphere of dharmic activity. May they exert themselves for the teachings and for the sake of sentient beings and be in harmony with one another; may their lives, their lotus feet, long be firm. Thereby may all harmful obstacles—both to the Dharma holders' activities that benefit the teachings and beings, and to your own and others' accomplishment of the Dharma—be pacified completely. May the activities of teaching and practicing the precious teachings grow more and more—the scriptures or so-called three baskets of the Vinaya, Sutra, and Abhidharma, and the path or three trainings of discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom.

Next is the aspiration for joy and happiness in this world.

May sickness, famine, war, and strife be quelled,

¹ That is, may they live long.

*The wealth of dharmic people greater grow,
The might of Dharma guardian kings increase,
And nations central and far-flung have joy.*

May diseases—sicknesses of wind, bile, and phlegm—and calamitous obstacles—hunger, thirst, poverty, and war—be pacified. May the wealth and fortune of all beings in this world grow greater and greater, especially that of all beings in lands where the sacred Dharma has spread and that of the faithful patrons of the teachings. May the might of the kings and ministers who guard the Dharma and have faith in its doctrines grow. May wanderers in all the vast nations east and west, central and outer, know happiness and peace of mind through love and kindness.

Next is the prayer for protection from fear and suffering.

*Protect me from all horrors present and future,
And from the sixteen fears, untimely death,
From nightmares and from evil omens,
Samsara's sufferings and lower realms.*

Pray that you are protected from this present life's sufferings of body and mind, from the future horrors, both subtle and gross, of suffering in samsara, and from the sixteen fears of this life: fire, water, lions, elephants, snakes, flesh-eating demons, iron shackles, thieves, leprosy, famine, enemies, lightning, punishment by kings, separation from friends, failure, and evil spirits. Pray also for protection from portentous dreams, evil omens or signs during the daytime—in short, from every kind of inauspicious sign. Pray for protection in future lives from the sufferings of the lower realms of the hells, hungry ghosts, and animals.

Then comes the particular aspiration for the generation of bodhicitta and so on.

*May long life, merit, power, and experience
And realization grow, unvirtuous thoughts not come;
May twofold bodhicitta rise in me without effort,
And grant my wishes in harmony with Dharma.*

May the short-term, worldly dharmas of longevity and merit, glory and fame, power and retinue—conditions agreeable to livelihood—grow in this life. Moreover, may the qualities, experience, and realization of hearing, pondering, and meditating on the sacred, transcendent Dharma be born in your mindstream and increase. May the unvirtuous thoughts of attachment, hatred, delusion, envy, pride, wrong view, and malicious intent to harm others never arise. In particular, may both precious relative bodhicitta of love and compassion and ultimate bodhicitta, which are yet unborn, be born in your mindstream without relying upon some immense effort. May that bodhicitta which has already been born not wither away, but increase more and more. In short, may all of your dharmic and worldly wishes be granted just as you wished them without going against the sacred Dharma, but acting in harmony with it.

Next make the aspiration to never be separated from Holy Tara.

*From now until the essence of enlightenment,
Look on me inseparably with compassion's eyes*

*Just as a mother looks upon her only son.
I pray to be made indivisible from you.*

Pray single-mindedly, “From now until I gain the state of enlightenment's essence, however long that takes, look on me with your eyes of compassion as inseparable from you during the six periods of day and night, just as a mother and father who have but one son would love and look after him. Temporarily act as my refuge and protector and ultimately for the sake of all sentient beings, I pray that you set me in buddhahood indivisibly from yourself, Arya Tara, and I too will perform the benefit of beings.”

Invocation & Mantra

*The image before me melts to light, then into
Me. Blessed as indivisible,
I myself become the body of
Arya Tara, appearing without nature.*

Holy Tara and her retinue, whom you have envisioned before you, melt into light and dissolve into you. Because you are blessed as inseparable from Arya Tara's body, speech, and mind, you actually become the body of Arya Tara, appearing but not existent by nature, like a reflection in a mirror. Meditating thus, recite the ten syllable mantra as many times as possible while your mind is focused on envisioning the divine body.

OM TARE TÛTTARE TÛRE SOHA

This, the root mantra of Tara, is the queen of all awareness mantras. It bestows all attainments. Its meaning is this: *OM* means the possessor of the supreme siddhi, wealth and enjoyments, glory, prosperity, and luck; it means the promise to practice the mantra, protector, auspiciousness, and holder of wealth. It is the mantra that gives rise to all wants and needs. *TARE TÛTTARE* is Tara's name. *TÛRE* means swift. *SOHA* means to pacify all misdeeds and obscurations, build up the accumulation of virtue higher and higher, eliminate the heap of faults and violations, and overcome all short and long-term suffering.

Here the text just says to focus on envisioning the divine body while reciting the mantra, but other texts say to envision that there is an eight-petaled utpala flower at Tara's heart center. On it is her life-force mantra, *TAM*, which is green in color. The ten syllable mantra, which faces inwards, is arranged clockwise around *TAM* and revolves counterclockwise. Green rays of light shine forth in all ten directions, making offerings to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas there. Their compassion and blessings merge within you. Then the rays of light once again shine forth and touch all the beings of the six realms, pacifying all their misdeeds, obscurations, faults, downfalls, sicknesses, demons, and obstacles. All sentient beings are Holy Tara's body, all realms her pure land, all appearances the deity, all sounds the mantra, all awareness primordial wisdom. It is good if you meditate on this while reciting the mantra. Moreover, I think it is also good if you can complete the visualization of the Vajrayana's four stakes that bind the life force¹. The four stakes are the view, the stake of dharmata; envisioning, the stake of the deity; reciting, the stake of mantra; and shining forth and converging, the stake of enlightened activity and blessing.

¹ For more information, see *Deity, Mantra, and Wisdom* translated by the Dharmachakra Translation Committee, which contains Patrul Rinpoche's “Meditating on the Four Stakes That Bind the Life Force.”

Confession of Mistakes

At the end, to confess the faults of adding to or omitting anything from the ritual, mantra, or samadhi and to make up for deficiencies, recite the hundred-syllable mantra of Vajrasattva. Then recite the following:

*Whatever I did not find or totally
Complete, or otherwise I could not do,
And in whatever deeds I've erred herein,
It's suitable if you forbear them all.*

Whatever offering materials you did not find, whatever visualizations, rituals, or mantras you failed to complete, the generation and completion stages, samayas, or siddhis you could not accomplish—whatever mistakes there are, acknowledge and confess them with all your heart. Pray that Arya Tara and the host of mandala deities have patience with them.

Evocation

Then, if you have an image of Tara, such as a statue or painting, imagine that she is present in this support and say:

*OM
Please remain together with this image
For as long as samsara, too, remains.
Bestow on me, please, freedom from disease,
And long life, power, and prosperity.
OM SŪTRA TIKTRA BENZA YEY SOHA*

If you do not have a support, recite the following evocation of Tara and the host of deities.

*OM
For sentient beings, you did everything,
Accordingly did you confer the siddhis.
I pray you go back to your buddhafiield,
I pray that once again you will return.*

Here you pray: “Arya Tara, you and your retinue did benefit to all us sentient beings with your blessings, helping us to amass the two accumulations and conferring the common and supreme siddhis according to the inclinations, aspirations, and merit of beings. Now having returned to your buddhafiields, the Field Arrayed in Turquoise Petals etc., I pray that once again you will return for the sake of all sentient beings.”

BENZA MÜ

This mantra means “I pray you come.”

Completion Stage

Then with the following two lines, you, who have given rise to yourself as the deity, as well as your retinue and so on, all dissolve within the completion stage.

*I remain in the authentic state, the dharma sphere,
Inseparability of my mind and the deity's.*

“I remain evenly within the mind's mode of being, the authentic primordial wisdom, the dharmadhatu, the inseparability of my mind and that of the supreme goddess Arya Tara, like water poured into water.” Thus maintain the view of the mode of being.

III. Dedication & Aspiration

*By this virtue, may I fast
Accomplish Arya Tara and
Establish beings in her state,
Not leaving even one behind.*

“*This virtue*” signifies all your own and other's roots of virtue in the three times. So you ought to make the dedication and aspiration this way: “By the power of this virtue, having attained the state of Holy Arya Tara, may I also establish all wanderers in the state of the Holy Bhagavati without leaving even one behind.”

Then, when making the following the aspiration for auspiciousness, toss flowers in the air at “*fortunate*”¹. Alternately, you may toss grains.

*May we be fortunate to never part
From Holy Tara, conquerors, and heirs,
And lucky to be kept by their compassion
Who grant all wishes unimpeded, like
The good vase or the wish-fulfilling jewel.*

“Day and night, at all six times, in this life and the next, and in the bardo, may we have the good fortune and virtue to never part from, and to be guarded and blessed by the tremendous love and compassion of, Holy Tara as well as the conquerors and their heirs, who, just by our praying to them, fulfill all our ends and wishes whatsoever without impediment, like the wish-fulfilling jewel that grants everything one wishes for just so, or like the good vase of vast treasure from which arises everything one might want or need.” Thus should you adorn the end of the sadhana beautifully.

In addition, the Great Master of Uddiyana said, “The view relates to scripture and reason. Meditation relates to experience. Conduct relates to time. Practice with these three relations.” Also, he has

¹ In the Tibetan, this occurs at the end of the stanza with the words *tashi shog* meaning, “May it be auspicious.”

said, “The ultimate, the visualization, and the expression, the door of words.” This means to put into practice without separating the words and their meanings, the expressions (the ritual words) and their referents (the ritual stages of visualization and so on). You must practice with the certainty and belief that, whatever deity you are practicing, that very deity specifically is the essence of infinite buddhas. The tantra *Compendium of Intent* says, “To practice one deity is to accomplish all of the unpracticed ones. Therefore, exert yourself on one without accepting or rejecting. With a mind that accepts and rejects, even if you practice many deities you will accomplish not a single one, but only bring about fatigue.” Thus know in the context of practicing Holy Arya Tara, also, that if you practice with the thought that she is the essence of all the conquerors in space and time, by practicing one deity you will accomplish all of them.

I, the nomad-wanderer Tsultrim Namdak Pel Zangpo, otherwise known as Khenpo Tsulnam, composed this commentary to *The Tara Ritual of Four Mandalas* in my room in Lunrig Jampel Ling, the great monastic university of Palpung Sherab Ling-the exile seat of Vajradhara Kenting Tai Situ Rinpoche in the north of India, a place of solitude in the midst of a cedar forest at the foot of the Himalayas. I composed it, beginning on the auspicious holiday of Buddha's first turning of the Dharma wheel, in hopes of benefiting some beginners on the path with interest in this particular teaching. May this composition become a cause for the spread of the teachings, the long lives of the lineage-holders, and for all beings, having partaken of the joys of the ocean of dharmic wealth, to attain the ultimate state of Arya Tara, the mother the Victors.

Bibliography

English Language Texts

Bokar Rinpoche. *Tara The Feminine Divine*. Translated from the French by Christiane Buchet. San Francisco: ClearPoint Press, 1999.

Jigme Lingpa, Patrul Rinpoche, and Getse Mahapandita. *Deity Mantra and Wisdom*. Translated by the Darmachakra Translation Committee. Ithaca, New York: Snow Lion Publications, 2006.

Khenchen Palden Sherab Rinpoche. *The Smile of Sun and Moon*. Translated by Anna Orlova. Boca Raton, Florida: Sky Dancer Press, 2004.

Lama Dondup Dorje(editor). *The Wish-Granting Tree of Enlightenment*. Translated by Lopen Phuntso Gyaltsen. Bylakuppe, India: Namdroling Monastery.

Orgyen Tobgyal Rinpoche. *The Life of Chokgyur Lingpa*. Translated by Tulku Jigme Khyentse and Erik Pema Kunsang. Kathmandu, Nepal: Rangjung Yeshe Publications, forthcoming.

Thubten Chodron. *How to Free Your Mind-Tara the Liberator*. Ithaca, NY: Snow Lion Publications, 2005.

Tulku Urgyen Rinpoche. *Blazing Splendor*. Translated by Eric Pema Kunsang and Marcia Binder Schmidt. Kathmandu, Nepal: Rangjung Yeshe Publications, 2005.

Tibetan Language Texts

dGe bshes thub bstan bsam 'grub. *ris med mkhas pa'i zhal lung*. Dharamsala, India: Sherig Parkang, 2005.

mKhen po tshul khrims rnam dag. *sGrol 'grel tshogs gnyis rgya mtshor 'jug pa'i gru gzings*. Upper Bhattu, India: Palpung Sungrab Partrun Kang, 2008.

Kun dga' snying po ta ra na tha. *sGrol ma'i 'grel pa*. Included in *'Dzam gling bde'i smon lam chen mo thengs bcu bdun pa'i skabs kyi deb ther*. Odiyan: Dharma Publishing, 2005.

_____. *sGrol ma'i rgyud kyi byung khungs gsal bar byed pa'i lo rgyus gser gyi phreng ba*. Included in *Dzam gling bde'i smon lam chen mo thengs bcu bdun pa'i skabs kyi deb ther*. Odiyan: Dharma Publishing, 2005.

About the Author

Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche was born in 1967 in Nangchen in eastern Tibet. He attended school for several years before becoming a monk at thirteen and beginning his study of Buddhism. He extensively studied sutra, tantra, and the Buddhist sciences of grammar, poetry, etc. at the monasteries Serta Larung, Arik, Drepung, and Trachok Yangwen. He has relied on many great masters including the scholar-siddha Karma Tseten, Dharma Lord Jigme Phuntsok, Chamgon Tai Situ Rinpoche, Khenchen Pema Tsewang, and His Holiness the Dalai Lama. Having received many empowerments, reading transmissions, and instructions from these masters, he mainly practices the profound paths of Mahamudra, Dzogchen, and the great Middle Way. Among the younger generation of Kagyupas in Tibet, he held the greatest number of lineages of empowerments, reading transmissions, and instructions. He completed a traditional three-year retreat and many other retreats of different lengths. He is the abbot of the monastic academy at Sherab Ling, the seat of Tai Situ Rinpoche in Himachal Pradesh in northern India. There he has spent many years giving teachings, empowerments, reading transmissions, and meditation instruction and nurturing the new generation of reincarnate lamas, khenpos, and the monastic Sangha in general. He has taught internationally for more than 20 years and has published books on the six bardos, the Heart Sutra, and other topics in Tibetan, English, and Chinese. Khenpo Tsulnam also gives Dharma advice and meditation instruction on cultivating tranquility and joy to prison inmates, people suffering from depression, and troubled youth. He founded a school for orphans and poor children of nomad families in eastern Tibet and is the founder of Gyalchi Palri Ling, an international organization promoting Buddhist education and charitable works.

About the Translator

Justin Kirkwood (Sherab Gyaltzen) is from the United States and is a student of Khenpo Tsulnam Rinpoche. He is novice monk in his third year of studies in the monastic university at Sherab Ling Monastery in India.